Backing up your work files

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Summary

This article explains how Acme Global employees can protect their work files by creating reliable backups using OneDrive, SharePoint, or local external media. It provides a step-by-step self-help guide for users to manually copy or sync important data, and a complementary procedure for service-desk agents to verify, troubleshoot, and restore backups when needed. Following these steps helps meet data-loss prevention goals and reduces downtime.

Symptoms

- Files appear missing from the OneDrive folder
- Error code 0x80070005 when trying to open a document
- Version history shows no prior versions
- Accidental deletion notification from SharePoint
- Unable to open a file due to a corruption warning

Common causes

- User-initiated delete or overwrite
- OneDrive sync conflict or paused sync
- Insufficient OneDrive storage quota
- Malware or ransomware encrypting local files
- Corrupted offline cache

Overview

Acme Global provides multiple ways to safeguard work files, primarily through OneDrive for Business synchronization and SharePoint document libraries. These services keep a cloud copy of your files and retain version history for up to 90 days, allowing recovery from accidental deletions or unwanted changes. This article outlines how to create an additional local backup when you need extra assurance, such as before major system changes or when working offline.

Prerequisites and Preparation

Before starting a manual backup, verify that your device is connected to the corporate network (either on-site Wi-Fi ACME-Corp or VPN GlobalProtect) so OneDrive can sync the latest changes. Ensure you have sufficient free space on the destination drive-external USB stick or secondary internal partition-at least twice the size of the data you intend to copy. Close any open files in Office applications to avoid lock conflicts.

Self-Help Procedure: Back Up Work Files

Follow these steps to copy your essential work folders to an external drive or a secondary location on your laptop. The process works on both Windows 11 and macOS devices managed by Intune.

1. Connect the external USB drive to your laptop and wait for it to appear in File Explorer (Windows) or Finder (macOS).
2. Open OneDrive folder (typically C:\Users\<username>\OneDrive - Acme Global on Windows or ~/OneDrive - Acme Global on macOS).
3. Select the folders or files you want to back up (e.g., Documents, Projects, Desktop). Right-click and choose Copy.
4. Navigate to the external drive, right-click inside the target folder, and choose Paste. Wait for the copy operation to complete; do not disconnect the drive until the progress bar disappears.
5. (Optional) Enable File History (Windows) or Time Machine (macOS) to schedule automatic hourly backups of the same location for ongoing protection.
6. Safely eject the external drive before removing it.

Verifying Your Backup

After copying, confirm that the backup is intact and accessible. Spot-check a few random files by opening them from the backup location to ensure they are not corrupted and reflect the latest changes you made before the backup. On Windows, you can also right-click the backed-up folder, select Properties, and compare the size and file count with the

source OneDrive folder. On macOS, use Get Info to perform the same comparison. If any discrepancies appear, repeat the copy process for the affected files.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports that they cannot locate a file or suspect data loss, follow this checklist to verify existing backups, recover missing data, and determine whether further escalation is required.

1. Ask the user to confirm the last known location of the missing file (OneDrive path, SharePoint library, or local folder).
2. Check the OneDrive recycle bin (https://onedrive.live.com/?id=root&cid=...) and restore if present; note that items remain for 93 days.
3. For SharePoint documents, go to the site's Recycle Bin (site contents -> Recycle bin) and restore if available.
4. If the file is not in either recycle bin, request the user to connect their external backup drive and navigate to the backup copy created using the self-help procedure.
5. Verify the backup file's timestamp and size; copy it back to the original OneDrive location, prompting the user to replace the existing file if prompted.
6. After restoration, ask the user to open the file to confirm integrity and then advise them to resume normal OneDrive sync.
7. If the backup drive fails to mount or shows I/O errors, escalate to Desktop Support for hardware diagnostics.
8. If the file remains missing after all the above steps, escalate to Messaging & Collaboration for deeper investigation of possible sync or retention policy issues.

Best Practices and Tips

Make backing up a habit: set a calendar reminder to perform a manual backup before major software updates, travel, or when working offline for extended periods. Keep at least two copies of critical data-one in the cloud (OneDrive/SharePoint) and one on an encrypted external drive. Store the external drive in a secure location when not in use, and remember that BitLocker (Windows) or FileVault (macOS) protects the drive if it is lost. Finally, always report suspicious activity or potential ransomware via the Outlook "Report Phishing" button so Security Operations can intervene early.

When to escalate

Escalate to Desktop Support when the user's external backup drive fails to mount, shows I/O errors, or the laptop's encrypted volume (BitLocker/FileVault) cannot be unlocked. Include the device asset tag, OS version, error messages from the drive, and a summary of steps already performed. Escalate to Messaging & Collaboration when the file is absent from OneDrive/SharePoint recycle bins, the user reports sync conflicts, or retention policies may have purged data. Provide the user's UPN, the exact file path, timestamps of last known good version, and any error codes from the OneDrive or SharePoint web interface.

Keywords: backup, OneDrive, SharePoint, file recovery, external drive, USB stick, data loss, version history, recycle bin, restore, self help, service desk, desktop support, messaging collaboration